NO. 153 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

WEDNESDAY 4 NOVEMBER 2026



NO COMPUTER IN IT, AND THAT IS WHY THEY KEEP IT (P15)

THE WORLD

Trump says Washington stops four billion dollars a year in military aid to Israel

TECHNOLOGY

Marvell agrees to buy Lumentum for $115bn, and its own shares fall 32 per cent

THE LONG READ

Thailand has frozen 3.56 million bank accounts; a third have no complainant

Source: a Bally "King Tut" of 1969, photographed for the Pacific Pinball Museum's own collection archive, Alameda, California.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 153

Contents

p3 The World — four billion dollars, said on television
p4 The World — the strike the President confirmed himself
p5 Singapore — head office goes to the baggage belt
p6 The Atelier — the cheap saw is the hard one
p7 Technology — a price that fell while it was announced
p8 The Home Lab — it worked on his machines, not theirs
p9 The Kit — three storage sizes, three processors
p10 The Good Life — the limitation that is only on the caseback
p11 Screen & Sound — a documentary at number one
p12–13 The Family Desk — puberty, and the move up
p14 The Macro Desk — all of it was the real rate
p15–17 The Rabbit Hole — pinball, and the machine you can fix
p18 Fitness — soy, pea and whey come out level
p19–20 The Diary — two ballots close this month
p21–23 The Long Read — Thailand's horse accounts

THE REFERENCE PRICE. Every number in this issue is a ratio to something it does not name. A premium measured against a share price the leak had already killed (p7). A yield that is two numbers added together, only one of which moved (p14). A benchmark that holds only when both machines run at full clock (p8). A hardness figure that means the saw is disposable (p6). And a seventy-nine per cent fall that counts what victims transferred, not what criminals earned (p21).

FROM THE DESK

"Everything is worth what its purchaser will pay for it."

Publilius Syrus, *Sententiae*, first century BC[1]

Which is the whole of p7, where the purchaser paid in his own shares and the price moved while he was saying it.

THE STRIP · AT TUESDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.95%	▲ 4bp
US 10-year real[2]	2.65%	▲ 3bp
10-yr breakeven	2.30%	desk's own
VWRA	$188.08	▼ 0.85%
AGGU	$5.81	▼ 0.12%
Gold spot	$3,922	▼ 0.63%
Bitcoin	$77,843	▲ 1.30%
Brent[3]	$103.60	▼ 1.12%
USD/SGD	1.2814	▲ 0.20%

Eighty-three of the eighty-two basis points were real (p14). Gold and bitcoin are evening spot reads, not exchange closes. Not advice.[2]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · NO. 73, AND THE LAW THIS DESK BROKE ON P4 AND KEPT

A Wednesday evergreen, since the Index runs Fridays and the Scoreboard Saturdays. Eighty issues ago a reader opened No. 73 and found the body copy crushed into three narrow justified columns.[4]

The rule that followed is now the oldest mechanical gate in the book. An article's running text is two columns at the full live-area width — never three, never squeezed beside a sidebar, never nested in a grid track.

It has been broken twice since and caught both times. No. 88 dodged the original check by putting its attributes in a different order; the gate was rebuilt as a tree walk that cannot be dodged.

The reason is not aesthetic. A column of about eighty-five millimetres holds roughly ten to twelve words a line, which is the measure the eye reads without losing its place. Three columns on A4 gives about seven.

The exception on this page is deliberate and is not running text. These six boxes are a strip, not an article — which is why they are allowed three columns and why they are this short.

And the same logic governs the figure on p14. A chart is allowed to span because nobody reads it as a sentence; a paragraph is not, because they do.

SOURCES 1 Publilius Syrus, *Sententiae*, a collection of maxims from the Latin mimes of the first century BC. 2 Levels at Tuesday 3 November's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14, where the United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves supply both yield lines and this desk's arithmetic supplies the breakeven. **Gold and bitcoin are evening spot reads, not exchange closes.** 3 A futures level, not an exchange settlement; **the official Brent spot series has not printed since 27 October.** 4 This magazine's own brand specification and Issue Log, Nos. 73 and 88.

THE WORLD · ISRAEL'S MILITARY AID

Trump says Washington stops $4bn a year in military aid to Israel

The memorandum signed under Obama says $3.8bn and runs to September 2028, and Netanyahu's office declined to comment — he has been a caretaker since 27 October.

President Donald Trump said on Tuesday morning, in a telephone interview with Fox News on the day of the American midterm elections, that he and Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu had agreed months ago to end annual United States military aid to Israel at the end of 2026. "*We were giving them $4 billion — we are — but it gets cut off at the end of the year*," he said. "*They don't need it.*"[1]

Israel has been the largest cumulative recipient of American foreign assistance since the Second World War, so ending the aid would be the biggest change to that relationship in a generation. Which is why how it was said matters as much as what was said. There is no document — only a television interview, a figure the President gave as four billion dollars, and no confirmation from the other party.[1]

The instrument is a ten-year memorandum signed under President Obama, effective from October 2018 and running to **September 2028**: **$3.8bn a year**, of which **$3.3bn** is grant finance for military purchases and **$500m** is joint missile defence, almost all of it required to be spent with American manufacturers. Trump said Netanyahu raised it first: "*He said, 'I think it would be appropriate if we do not receive aid.'*" In January, Netanyahu said he wanted to taper the aid over the next decade.[2]

The counterparty is provisional too. Israel voted on **27 October** and produced no majority — Netanyahu's bloc **53 seats**, Gadi Eisenkot's **48**. President Herzog begins coalition consultations today, and the new Knesset is sworn in on **10 November**. Netanyahu's office declined to comment; the State Department did not respond. Brent fell about **three per cent to $101** on the remarks, recovering to **$103** by midday in New York.[3]

THE CHATTER · HOW ISRAEL'S POLITICIANS HEARD TRUMP

The complaint from the opposition was about the channel, not the policy. **Gadi Eisenkot**, former chief of staff of the Israeli army, whose bloc came second on 27 October, said the public had learned of a strategic shift through the media and that Netanyahu "*can no longer be trusted, and he must be replaced*". **Yair Golan**, who leads The Democrats, said ending the aid would seriously damage Israeli security and called it another failure. In Washington, **Thomas Warrick** of the Atlantic Council expects no stop at all on 31 December but a phase-out across 2027, because missile-defence programmes cannot easily be moved onto a commercial footing.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY THE ISRAEL AID CANNOT STOP ON 31 DECEMBER

The money is contracted to September 2028, and *The Times of Israel* wrote in its own voice that Trump's claim **"appears to almost certainly be false"** in the light of it. A president cannot end it alone: Congress appropriates the funds each year, as Al Jazeera's White House correspondent **Kimberly Halkett** pointed out on air, calling the timing a "*November surprise*". And the President's figure does not match the paper — **$4bn against $3.8bn**. **What would settle it:** a written notification to Congress, or a line in the next budget request. **Neither exists today.**[5]

$175bn

CUMULATIVE AMERICAN BILATERAL ASSISTANCE AND MISSILE-DEFENCE FUNDING TO ISRAEL TO DATE[6]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Washington suspends South Africa and Rwanda from duty-free African trade access on 1 January 2027. South Africa, the largest beneficiary, shipped about **$1.7bn** under the programme in 2025. Neither government responded at once.[7]

SOURCES 1 Trump on *Fox & Friends*, 3 November 2026, quoted from Fox News's own write-up, with NBC News and Al Jazeera the same morning. **There is no written primary document — no transcript, no readout, no post. The interview is the record.** 2 The 2016 memorandum's terms via NBC News and *The Times of Israel*, 3 November; Netanyahu's January position via the same two. 3 Knesset arithmetic and the consultation timetable — **this desk could not reach the election commission's own pages**; oil levels from NBC News. 4 Eisenkot and Golan via NBC News; Halkett and Warrick on Al Jazeera, 3 November. 5 *The Times of Israel* liveblog, 3 November, 16:01. 6 Congressional Research Service figures as compiled by TRT World, 3 November. 7 Al Jazeera, 2 November; **no legal instrument has been published.** 8 United Nations News, 1 November 2026.

THE WORLD · QESHM ISLAND

Trump confirms American jets hit a new Iranian air-defence site on Qeshm

He called it "a minor attack" and said the site had been watched for two months. Iran's Revolutionary Guard says three tankers hit mines in Hormuz the same day.

Five explosions struck Qeshm Island, in the Strait of Hormuz, late on Monday 2 November, with further blasts at Bandar Lengeh; Iran's state agency quoted witnesses who saw two aircraft overhead. American media attributed the strikes to the United States military. Central Command said nothing. Then on Tuesday morning the President confirmed it himself, on Fox News: "*They built an anti-aircraft facility... As soon as it was completed, we hit it last night very nicely.*" He called it "*a minor attack*" and said the site had been watched going up for about two months.[1]

The Guard's naval arm answered in kind, and in claims. Its own outlet said **three "violating" oil tankers** caught fire after striking naval mines while running an unauthorised route with their identification systems switched off, and were abandoned off the strait's southern coast. **No vessel was named and no casualty figure given.** The Guard also said it had brought down three American drones. None of it is independently confirmed.[2]

What is confirmed is a death. India's foreign ministry said on Tuesday that of **fourteen Indian nationals** aboard the vessel MSV *Al Jusufi*, attacked near Limah on the Omani coast on Monday evening, **thirteen were rescued and one died** — bringing to **23** the Indian dead in this conflict since 28 February, fifteen of them seafarers. Meanwhile the reopening file has not moved: Qatar's spokesman **Majed Al Ansari** said only that "*bridging the gap is still a work in progress*".[3]

DOHA — AL JAZEERA

Grants the strike to nobody on the record: explosions hit Qeshm "as US media report US strikes", "*defensive strikes*" stays inside quotation marks, and the attribution is attributed — to the *Wall Street Journal*, the Associated Press, Fox and Axios, not to any official.[4]

MINSK — TASS

Files it as a security-bloc concern rather than an American operation. **Taalatbek Masadykov**, secretary general of the Collective Security Treaty Organisation: "*The dangerous consequences of military action by the United States and Israel against Iran are particularly alarming*" — noting a draft bill in Iran's parliament on leaving the non-proliferation treaty.[4]

BEIJING — GLOBAL TIMES

Reads the crisis through the American ballot. **Wu Xinbo** of Fudan University says midterms usually turn on domestic questions but "*this one is different*," the repercussions "*concentrated in the Middle East*". His colleague **Zhang Jiadong** disagrees.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT NOBODY HAS SHOWN ABOUT THE QESHM STRIKE

Central Command has issued no statement, and there is no photograph of the site. The strike is attributed by American reporters citing officials who are not named, and confirmed only by a president describing it in a radio-style interview as minor. The mine claim is worse served: three tankers reportedly burned and nobody has produced a name, a flag or a crew list. **What would settle it:** a vessel name from a maritime authority.[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Russian bombs killed at least 31 people at a Zaporizhzhia aid point on Monday. The school at Komyshuvakha, used every Monday to hand out food, was hit, and then hit again — **nine more bombs** on the shelter where survivors and rescuers had taken cover. By Tuesday evening the regional administration counted **31 dead, 58 missing**; President Zelensky said 33. **Danielle Bell** of the UN human-rights mission: Russian forces either knew, "*or they failed to take the most basic steps to find out... In either case, this attack seems to have violated the most fundamental principles of international humanitarian law.*" Moscow says it struck soldiers.[5]

Israeli forces left Hebron on 2 November after a ten-day siege. The governorate counts **537 families** moved out at night and **327 shops** closed.[6]

SOURCES 1 Iranian state-agency reports of 2 November via Al Jazeera and *The Times of Israel*; Trump's confirmation via TRT World and Kurdistan24, 3 November. **Central Command did not respond and its own site refused this desk.** 2 The Revolutionary Guard's naval arm via its own outlet, reported by Xinhua from Tehran, 3 November. **These are the Guard's claims and are unverified.** 3 India's Ministry of External Affairs statement of 3 November, read as quoted by ThePrint and Arab News (**the ministry's own site refused this desk**); the Qatari briefing via Xinhua, Doha. 4 Al Jazeera, 3 November; TASS, Minsk, 3 November; *Global Times*, 2 November, 22:56. 5 The Zaporizhzhia regional administration's own channel, timestamped 2 and 3 November; Danielle Bell via Interfax-Ukraine, 3 November, 20:38; the Russian account via the Reuters wire. **The two Ukrainian counts differ and both are given.** 6 Al Jazeera, 2 November 2026. 7 Reserve Bank of Australia media release 2026-30, 3 November 2026, read at source.

SINGAPORE · THE BAGGAGE BELT

SATS sends office staff to the baggage belt as MOM investigates 45 contractors

The ministry found Employment Pass holders handling bags and says the declared salaries were false. A day later, SATS asked desk staff to volunteer for 2.5-hour shifts.

The Ministry of Manpower said on Monday 2 November that it is investigating about 45 companies working at Changi Airport over roughly **270 workers** whose deployment may breach work-pass rules. The workers are employed by contractors and sub-contractors to **SATS**, the ground-handling company, which the ministry named. Its finding is specific: people holding Employment Passes were found handling baggage, and "*the salaries and occupations declared to MOM for the EP holders were false*".[1]

An Employment Pass is the pass for professionals and managers. It is not the pass for lifting suitcases, which is why the declarations had to be wrong for the arrangement to work at all. The offences carry a fine of up to **$20,000** and up to **two years** in prison for a false declaration, and up to **$10,000** for illegal deployment, plus a possible bar on hiring pass holders. The ministry has directed SATS to check its contractors' deployment against their passes.[1]

The consequence arrived within a day. On **3 November** SATS emailed staff thanking them for operational support in recent weeks and encouraging them to volunteer for **baggage-handling duties**, particularly over the Deepavali long weekend; non-operational departments were encouraged too. Volunteers taking **two-and-a-half-hour blocks** are reported to receive a transport allowance, time off in lieu and **$15 in vouchers**. SATS says it "may temporarily redeploy employees across different work areas", with training and supervision, and that it regularly invites staff to volunteer at peak periods.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE FORUMS SAID ABOUT THE CHANGI PASSES

The sympathy on the local boards runs to the system, not the pass holder. On HardwareZone's Eat-Drink-Man-Woman board the sharper thread this week was not the SATS probe but a migrant worker whose permit was revoked after he publicly asked for a two-thousand-dollar minimum wage. **MizunoVolley**: "*Sinkie also no minimum wage, he think he above sinkie*". **trd_charlie**: "*How about showing a little gratitude*". The probe itself drew less heat than the airline data breach on the next board along.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY CHANGI'S PASSES WERE MIS-DECLARED

The ministry locates the fault in 45 companies. Its own published rules suggest arithmetic. **The Employment Pass carries no quota and no levy.** The S Pass is capped at **ten per cent** of a services firm's headcount and costs **$650 a month** a head; work permits and S Passes together are capped at **35 per cent**, the tightest ceiling of any sector. A ground handler that has used up both has one uncapped, levy-free channel left — and its price of entry is a declared salary, precisely the thing alleged to have been falsified. **The counter:** a false declaration is a crime whatever the arithmetic.[4]

270

WORKERS WHOSE DEPLOYMENT THE MINISTRY IS EXAMINING, ACROSS ABOUT 45 COMPANIES[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

About 46,000 Singapore Airlines booking records were exposed in a breach at Amadeus, its Spanish reservations provider; for about **620** of them, contact and travel-document details may also have been reached. No payment data, no booking altered. Cathay Pacific, Japan Airlines, Korean Air and Malaysia Airlines were also affected.[5]

Amendments to the Administration of Muslim Law Act had their second reading on 3 November, recognising the Singapore College of Islamic Studies — first cohort **2028** — and making children's welfare the paramount consideration in Syariah Court custody orders.[6]

SOURCES 1 Ministry of Manpower press release, 2 November 2026, read at source; the penalties are those the release states. **It names no official.** 2 AsiaOne, 3 November 2026, reporting the internal email and SATS's statement. **The voucher, the block length and the time off in lieu come from an anonymous employee quoted by** The Straits Times **and are unconfirmed by the company; that paper refused this desk.** 3 HardwareZone threads of 2 and 3 November 2026, handles as displayed. **Reddit refused this desk entirely.** 4 Pass eligibility, levy and dependency-ratio figures from the ministry's own pages; unemployment from its third-quarter advance release of 30 October 2026. 5 AsiaOne, 3 November 2026, quoting Amadeus and an unnamed airline spokesman. **Single-sourced: the airline's media pages and the provider's security notice both returned nothing.** 6 AsiaOne, 3 November 2026. **Parliament's own pages served no data.**

BUY IT ONCE · HAND SAWS

A hardware-shop saw is harder than Lie-Nielsen's, and cannot be sharpened

Lie-Nielsen tempers its plate to 50–52 on the Rockwell scale so a file can cut it. A hardware-shop saw runs 68 to 71, and is thrown away.

A hand saw is one of the few tools built to be worn out, and this page is about the choice that decides which kind you own — whether the teeth can be sharpened. Nearly every saw in a hardware shop has teeth hardened by a jolt of electricity at the tip. They cut well, they cut for a long time, and when they blunt they cannot be filed, because no file is hard enough to touch them. You buy another saw.[1]

The good ones go the other way on purpose. A maker who means his saw to last a lifetime leaves the steel *softer* than the throwaway, so a file bites and the edge can be restored every few years. That is the category in one sentence, and it inverts the instinct you bring to it: here, harder is the disposable one.[1]

The numbers. Lie-Nielsen tempers its Swedish plate to **50–52 Rockwell C**, Bad Axe its 1095 spring steel to **49–52**, Blackburn to **48–51** — hard enough to hold an edge in oak, soft enough for a file, which sits near 62. A Gyokucho impulse-hardened blade is specified at **68–71**, and DICTUM prints the consequence on its own page: "*hardness over 70 HRC, cannot be resharpened.*" Bahco sells the other philosophy honestly — hardpoint teeth last **up to five times longer**, then the saw is replaced.[1]

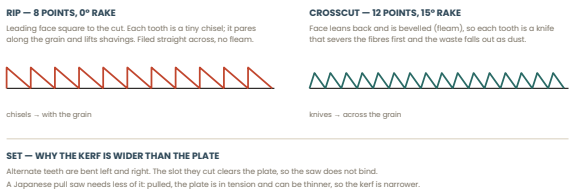
In hand saws, harder is the disposable one.

THE CHATTER · WHAT WOODWORKERS SAY ABOUT EXPENSIVE SAWS

The owners are the least starry-eyed. **Megan Fitzpatrick** on *Never Sponsored*, December 2024: "*each of the saws pictured above costs more than my first car*". **Christopher Schwarz** on Lie-Nielsen: "*the best traditional-looking Western saws on the market*" — with the warning he attaches: "*If you are a beginner, these saws will not help you… don't cry to me if you whammy a $600 saw.*"[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHERE HAND-SAW PRICING IS THEATRE

A sharpened vintage Disston does the job at a sixth of the price. A 26-inch five-point rip D-12 sold at a dealer for **$95**; a Bad Axe D8 is **$550**. **ErnieConover**: "*You should not need to pay more than about $20 and will get a saw of far superior quality to any you can purchase today.*" **JeffHeath**, in the same thread, says bargain saws will not match a Lie-Nielsen *unless professionally sharpened* — which is the real variable. And the ornament is where the premium lands: Bad Axe prices handle wood, fastener finish, thumbhole and plate etch separately, every one cosmetic.[4]



Rip teeth are chisels filed square to the cut; crosscut teeth lean back and are bevelled, so each is a knife. *Meridian* original, drawn from the rake and fleam figures Tools for Working Wood publishes for its own saws.[2]

S$0

VERIFIED SINGAPORE STOCKISTS OF LIE-NIELSEN, VERITAS OR GYOKUCHO; THE HUNT FOUND OVERSEAS RETAILERS ONLY, AND LIE-NIELSEN'S PLATE HAS "NO RUST-INHIBITING ALLOYS ADDED"[5]

NEXT ON THE BENCH · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S CATEGORY

Secateurs & loppers — bypass against anvil, and who still sells a spare blade.

Oil lamps & lanterns — wick, draught and glass, and who still cold-rolls a burner.

Cast-iron kettles & tetsubin — sand-mould against machine-pressed iron.

SOURCES 1 Hardness figures read on each maker's own product page, 3–4 November 2026 — Lie-Nielsen, Bad Axe, Blackburn, Gyokucho via a specialist retailer, and DICTUM, whose page carries the "cannot be resharpened" line verbatim. **The explanation of why filing through a hardened case fails could only be read on a retailer page that errored, so the mechanism rests on the hardness figures alone.** 2 Maker pages and price lists, read 3 November 2026, with the rake and fleam from Tools for Working Wood's own listing. **No maker in this survey publishes a handle hang angle in degrees.** 3 *Never Sponsored*, 12 December 2024. 4 Fine Woodworking forum threads of 2005 and 2010, handles as displayed; Bad Axe's own option list. 5 Searches for Singapore stockists returned manufacturer and overseas-retailer pages only.

TECHNOLOGY · THE MARVELL DEAL

Marvell agrees to buy Lumentum for $115bn; its own shares fall 32%

The price is 4.5 Marvell shares per Lumentum share. By Tuesday's close those were worth $773.87, not the $1,132.43 announced on Monday.

Marvell Technology signed an agreement on Sunday 1 November to buy Lumentum, the American maker of the lasers that carry data between artificial-intelligence computers, and announced it on **Monday** at a headline value of **$115bn** — the largest semiconductor merger of the year. Marvell is paying no cash: each Lumentum share is to be exchanged for **4.500 new Marvell shares**.[1]

That last detail is the story. When a buyer pays in its own shares, what the seller actually receives rises and falls with the buyer's share price — and Marvell's has been falling hard. At Tuesday's close the 4.5 shares were worth **$773.87**, a third less than the **$1,132.43** the announcement described, and the whole transaction was worth about **$78.7bn**. Marvell's own shareholders have taken about **$66bn** off the company in three sessions — more than half what it says it is paying.[2]

The reference price is the tell. The agreement puts the premium at **23.9 per cent** over Lumentum's close on **28 October**, which the filing calls the unaffected date. Bloomberg reported advanced talks that same day. Marvell then fell **13.24 per cent** and **10.05 per cent** on the two sessions following, so by signing day the Marvell those shares were priced against had gone.[2]

The filings promise **more than $1bn** a year of savings against pro forma revenue of **$17.7bn**, and a long wait: the signed outside date is **1 November 2027**, extendable three times to **1 August 2028**, with closing expected in the first half of that year.[1]

The asset is not in doubt: Lumentum reported the same morning that quarterly revenue reached **$1,262.6m**, up **136.5 per cent** on the year. The argument is about structure, timing and price.[3]

THE CHATTER · HOW THE TRADE READ THE LUMENTUM DEAL

Two downgrades landed on Tuesday. **Vivek Arya** of Bank of America went to Neutral and cut his Marvell target from **$400 to $225**, writing that the "*$1 billion in cost cuts falls short of offsetting about 50% share dilution*" and asking what happens to Lumentum's valuation "*once its laser shortages are inevitably resolved*". **Sean O'Loughlin** of TD Cowen went to Hold at **$175**, from $350, citing "*our negative view of the transaction itself in terms of structure and timing, rather than the quality of the asset*". The street has not turned — **25 of 27** analysts still rate Marvell a buy. One measure of attention: the Reuters report of the year's biggest chip merger drew **five points and no comments** on Hacker News.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT MARVELL IS PAYING FOR LUMENTUM

$115bn against $5.05bn of annualised revenue is 22.8 times sales, on a business whose growth is itself a function of a laser shortage. Nor do the companies expect an easy passage: Marvell will pay Lumentum **$3.2bn** if the deal fails on regulatory grounds — larger than the **$2.9bn** Lumentum owes for walking away. The arbitrageurs agree: Lumentum closed Tuesday **12.1 per cent below** the exchange ratio's own value, a wide spread for a signed, board-approved deal. **What would settle it:** a cleared antitrust review, or a Marvell share price that puts the two numbers back together.[5]

$66bn

TAKEN OFF MARVELL'S OWN MARKET VALUE IN THREE SESSIONS — ITS WORST THREE-DAY RUN SINCE OCTOBER 2000[4]

ALSO ON THE DESK

onsemi agreed on 2 November to buy Ferric for $600m in cash plus up to $175m tied to revenue, lifting its 2030 data-centre target by $500m to more than $3bn.[6]

Anthropic's amended share-offering document of 2 November still leaves the price range blank, and nothing has been filed since. It names 22 underwriters and the ticker ANT against nine-month revenue of **$33.2bn**.[7]

SOURCES 1 Marvell's Form 8-K of 2 November 2026 and the merger agreement filed as its exhibit 2.1, with the joint release and investor deck filed the same day, all read in full on the Securities and Exchange Commission's own system. 2 Daily closes for both shares, 27 October to 3 November 2026; the premium, the per-share value and the $115.2bn are this desk's own arithmetic from those closes and Lumentum's 101.7m diluted share count. **Bloomberg's 28 October report of advanced talks is cited as reported; this desk could not read it at source.** 3 Lumentum's results release for the quarter ended 26 September 2026, filed 2 November. 4 Bank of America and TD Cowen notes of 3 November via Investing.com; the Hacker News counts read from that site's own search interface. 5 The multiple and the spread are this desk's arithmetic; the fees are quoted from the 8-K. **No regulator has said anything and no docket exists.** 6 onsemi's Form 8-K of 2 November 2026. 7 Anthropic's Form S-1/A of 2 November 2026, compared line by line against the 26 October original.

THE HOME LAB · TWO MACHINES, ONE MODEL

llama.cpp splits one model across two Nvidia machines; its founder measured no gain

An Nvidia engineer merged it on 3 November, forty-nine days after filing. On the author's pair it read documents 59 per cent faster; on the founder's, nothing.

The free program most people use to run artificial-intelligence models on their own computers accepted a change on Tuesday 3 November that lets two separate machines work on the same model at the same moment, over a network. It was filed on **15 September** by a developer posting as zyang-dev and merged, after forty-nine days of review, by an engineer at Nvidia.[1]

This matters to anyone who has run out of memory on one machine. Splitting a big model across two computers used to mean handing each a different slice of the work and waiting while they passed the job back and forth. The new code has both machines perform the same step together, over the fast direct links data centres use. On the author's own pair, reading a long document got about **sixty per cent** quicker. On the pair belonging to the man who founded the project, it got no quicker at all.[2]

The measurements, from the author's two Nvidia DGX Spark nodes connected over RDMA, running a 27-billion-parameter Qwen model at four-bit precision: prompt processing went from **846.54 to 1,348.29 tokens a second** against a single node, **1.59×**; generation from **13.02 to 23.51**, **1.81×**. The patch is pull request 28967, three files, **333 lines added and 57 removed**.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE LLAMA.CPP THREAD SAID

There is no forum reaction, and this desk checked rather than assumed: no Hacker News item, no findable subreddit thread. The pull request *is* the record. **gaugarg-nv**, the Nvidia engineer who merged it: "*This provides a much faster path on Nvidia GPUs.*" And the community's standing advice says the opposite of the patch: the DGX Spark runtime guide recommends "*llama.cpp for single node only and…vLLM or SGLang for multi-node workloads.*"[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT LLAMA.CPP'S NVIDIA NUMBERS NEED

llama.cpp's headline figure requires two identical, fully-clocked Nvidia Sparks on a fast fabric. When one node clocks down the whole benefit goes — the founder's result, not a critic's. Most of the generation win was already there: the earlier two-node split gave 1.72×, this takes it to 1.81×. Off a fast fabric it is actively harmful — an earlier thread measured tensor mode at about **8 tokens a second of prompt processing over gigabit Ethernet against 100** for the ordinary layer split. **And for a Mac:** on two M3 Ultras over Metal, layer split beat tensor split **23.05 against 9.61** on generation. This is a CUDA feature.[4]

49

DAYS FROM FILING TO MERGE, NO OUTSIDE REPRODUCTION YET[1]

ALSO ON THE BENCH

A faster exchange for Intel's Arc cards merged on 2 November, its author measuring prompt processing up **16.7 to 20.6 per cent** on two Arc Pro B70s — but a second tester measured a small generation **regression**, and a third saw no gain at all on three cards.[5]

Graph optimisations for Google's Gemma models merged 3 November took prompt processing on an Apple M4 Pro from **1,613.78 to 4,603.18 tokens a second**, 2.85×. Generation did not move, and the gain is switched off whenever more than one sequence is served.[6]

SOURCES 1 Pull request 28967 on the llama.cpp repository, opened 15 September 2026 and merged 3 November 2026; the benchmark table, the file counts and the merge commit read on the request's own page. 2 The review thread on the same page; comments of 17 and 28 October 2026 quoted verbatim, with their authors' handles as shown. 3 The merge thread as above; the runtime guide at sparkrun.dev, undated; the absence of outside discussion confirmed against Hacker News's own search interface and a subreddit search, 4 November 2026. 4 The gigabit-Ethernet and Metal measurements are from the earlier two-node request's thread, posted by third-party testers on their own hardware. 5 Pull request 30956, merged 2 November 2026, with the author's and two testers' tables. 6 Pull request 31356, merged 3 November 2026. 7 The vLLM release notes of 2 November 2026; **the page tags the release as a candidate build, so the final version string may differ.**

THE KIT · THE IPAD MINI

Apple's OLED iPad mini reaches Singapore on Friday from S$999

Apple sorts the chip by storage size: only the S$1,449 model carries six processor cores and two on-device AI units, against five and one beneath it.

Apple opened pre-orders for its new iPad mini in Singapore on 29 October and puts it in shops on **Friday 6 November**, starting at **S$999** and running to **S$1,599**. The first independent reviews landed on Tuesday, two days before anyone here can buy one.[1]

The screen is the advertised change — it is the first small Apple tablet with the kind of panel that lights each dot individually, so black is genuinely black. The more consequential change is one Apple states only in a table. The three storage sizes do not contain the same processor. The cheaper two get a chip with five working cores and a single unit for running artificial-intelligence models on the device itself; the largest gets six cores and two of those units. Nothing in the marketing says so.[2]

In full: the 128GB and 256GB tiers run the A20 Pro with five processor cores and one 16-core Neural Engine; the 512GB at **S$1,449** runs the same part with six cores and **two**. The panel is an 8.5-inch 2316×1512 OLED, 1,200 nits at peak, in a body **5.4mm thick** and **255g** heavy.[2]

Singapore's own reviewer got the numbers first. **Kenny Yeo** of HardwareZone measured Geekbench 6 at **4,651 single-core and 12,602 multi-core** against the previous mini's 2,817 and 6,982 — multi-core up **80.5 per cent**, graphics up **140 per cent**. Against the far dearer iPad Pro it is the stranger result: the mini is **13.8 per cent faster single-core** than the M5 and **21 per cent slower** across all cores.[3]

The battery is the soft spot. **Nathan Ingraham** of Engadget, scoring it 8.5, got **"about 5 to 6 hours of heavy use"** against Apple's claimed ten,; charging measured **29 to 74 per cent in thirty minutes**. The cell is **18.9Wh** — about two per cent smaller than the one it replaces.[4]

THE CHATTER · WHAT OWNERS SAID ABOUT THE IPAD MINI

The launch thread on the MacRumors forums ran to sixteen pages, and the complaint was unanimous and unexpected: not the price, the refresh rate. **joshwithachance**, the most-endorsed post on page one at 88 reactions: "*Officially still 60Hz… Pass.*" **Aka757** (45): "*60 hz with an OLED panel is pathetic*". The counterweight came on price, not specification — **dmr727**: "*Still 60Hz, but at $699 this will still be a buy for me.*" And **MayaUser**, reading the binned-chip line aloud: "*what the hell*".[5]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT APPLE WILL NOT PRINT ABOUT THE IPAD MINI

Apple's Singapore specification page never states the refresh rate at all. This desk read the whole page: no "ProMotion", no "Hz". Reviewers had to infer 60 and then confirm it by eye. It also omits the memory, the battery capacity, and any output figure for the speaker system Apple calls an advance. The price moved **S$699 to S$999, up 43 per cent**, which Yeo lays at the memory shortage rather than the screen. **What would settle it:** a published refresh figure, or an independent measurement of those speakers.[6]

43%

MORE THAN THE CHEAPEST IPAD MINI COST AT ITS PREVIOUS SINGAPORE LAUNCH — S$699 TO S$999[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Samsung put sleep-apnoea detection on the Galaxy Ring. Announced 3 November, on a clearance granted in July; it wants five hours of sleep on two nights within ten days and grades the result mild, occasional or frequent. **Samsung publishes no sensitivity or specificity figure.**[7]

Sigma's fp II goes on sale 11 November at US$2,199 for the body — 24.5 megapixels, partially stacked, **electronic shutter only**, 6K open-gate recording to 70GB of internal storage, 446g, and no stabiliser in the body.[8]

SOURCES 1 Apple's Singapore store page for the iPad mini, read 4 November 2026: pre-order open, "available starting 6 November", six units per customer, prices inclusive of goods-and-services tax. 2 Apple's own Singapore technical-specification page, read in full the same morning; the per-tier processor differences appear in its table and nowhere in its marketing copy. 3 Kenny Yeo, HardwareZone Singapore, 3 November 2026; his comparison table also carries the previous generation's Singapore prices. 4 Nathan Ingraham, Engadget, 3 November 2026. A third review, at TechRadar, published the same day; **its body would not render for this desk on two attempts, so nothing is quoted from it.** 5 The MacRumors launch thread, opened 26 October 2026; reaction counts as shown on page one. **Reddit refused this desk entirely, so the owner read rests on one forum.** 6 Apple's specification page as above; Yeo for the price history and the nano-texture verdict. 7 Steve Dent, Engadget, 3 November 2026. 8 New Atlas, 26 October 2026; **Sigma's own page was not read.**

THE GOOD LIFE · THE HERITAGE CHRONOGRAPH

H. Moser limits its new Heritage Chronograph to 100 pieces at CHF 29,200

About S$45,600 for a steel 42mm watch good to 30 metres. The caseback is engraved "LIMITED 100 PCS"; the maker's own product page gives no edition size at all.

The Schaffhausen watchmaker H. Moser introduced the Heritage Chronograph White Fumé on Monday 2 November, reference 8220-1200, a steel case of 42 millimetres limited to **100 pieces** at **CHF 29,200** — about **S$45,600**. It is the Schaffhausen company's first chronograph in its Heritage line, and a swerve for a maker better known for dials with nothing written on them at all.[1]

The dial is white with a sunburst fade, the chronograph markings blue, the logo the one Moser used in 1947, the strap grey kudu. The movement is the house calibre with a **72-hour** reserve, running at 3 hertz on 51 jewels, with a Straumann hairspring — Moser owns the company that makes those, which is the genuine vertical integration here. The chronograph itself is a module from Dubois Dépraz, bolted on top. That is not a secret; it is what keeps the price below the integrated chronographs Moser builds with Agenhor.[2]

Moser opened its first standalone Southeast Asian boutique at Raffles City with Cortina Watch in January. **No Singapore price for this reference has been published that this desk could locate**, and the brand's own retailer locator would not render.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT COLLECTORS SAID ABOUT THE MOSER CHRONOGRAPH

Thin, and honestly so — the watch is forty-eight hours old and no forum thread on the reference existed as this page closed. What there is runs to size and money. On Monochrome's own comment thread, **Hakan**, 2 November 19:38: "*The size ruined it for me.*" **Laslo Mesaros**, the next morning: "*Yes, the size and price?*" The reviewer, **Brice Goulard**, calls the watch "*fairly surprising, at least by Moser's modern standards*" and "*more vintage in design than in proportions*". **Hodinkee refused this desk entirely, so the enthusiast read rests on two named commenters and one reviewer. This desk will not manufacture a consensus that has not formed.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT MOSER WILL NOT PRINT ABOUT REF. 8220-1200

The maker's own product page omits the limitation — the thing the price rests on — while the caseback is engraved **"LIMITED 100 PCS"**. It also omits the case thickness, the frequency and the jewel count; all three appear only in press material. It quotes **CHF 27,000 excluding tax** where the retail figure is 29,200. And the currency pricing is segmentation, not arithmetic: at Tuesday's reference rates CHF 29,200 converts to **EUR 31,857** and Moser charges **34,100**, about **seven per cent over**; the same francs convert to **US$35,612** and Moser charges **34,100**, about four per cent under. Meanwhile a retailer displays **"4.7 average stars" from 8 reviews** on a 100-piece watch that shipped two days ago and cannot be bought, and calls the movement in-house. **What would settle it:** an edition size on the maker's own page.[5]

CHF 13,500

WHAT THE BOUGHT-IN CHRONOGRAPH MODULE COSTS, READ OFF MOSER'S OWN TWO LAUNCHES OF THE SAME MORNING[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Audemars Piguet showed three Supersonnerie minute repeaters on 2 November, one a Royal Oak in titanium limited to **50 pieces**. All use calibre 2953 and are good to **20 metres**. **Price on request, and no limitation published for the gold versions.**[6]

Louis Vuitton put the Tambour Convergence in mirror-polished hardened steel at **1130 Vickers**, 37mm, in-house calibre, **EUR 26,000** including tax — about S$37,200. Permanent collection, not limited.[7]

SOURCES 1 H. Moser & Cie.'s own Heritage collection page for reference 8220-1200, read 3 November 2026; the retail price and limitation from the launch coverage of 2 November. 2 Monochrome, 2 November 2026, from the press material; the caseback engraving read in that article's own photograph. 3 Cortina Watch's announcement of 29 January 2026; **the brand's retailer locator is script-rendered and returned an empty page to this desk.** 4 Monochrome's comment thread, read at source with dates and times as displayed. **Hodinkee blocked this desk; no forum thread on the reference existed at press.** 5 The maker's own page against the press specification; conversions at the European Central Bank's reference rates for 3 November 2026; the retailer listing read the same day. 6 SJX Watches, 3 November 2026. 7 Monochrome, 3 November 2026. 8 Monochrome, 2 November 2026.

SCREEN & SOUND · A DOCUMENTARY AT NO. 1

A24's Elizabeth Holmes documentary topped the US box office for a third weekend

It took $11,445,629 from 3,243 theatres, reaching $64.7m. No documentary has led the American box office since Michael Moore in 2004.

"You Can See Everything", Nathan Fielder and Lance Oppenheim's film about Elizabeth Holmes, led the American box office over the weekend of 30 October to 1 November, its third, taking **$11,445,629** from **3,243** theatres — down 38.9 per cent, on 588 more screens — for **$64,727,541** in all. It is the first documentary other than a concert film to lead the American box office since *Fahrenheit 9/11* in 2004.[1]

It is also **two hours and fifty-four minutes** long, which makes it the first nearly-three-hour documentary ever to lead in a second weekend, and the fourth documentary ever to play more than 3,000 theatres. The film follows Holmes for what became a three-year shoot, beginning about thirty-four days before she was due to report to prison. The overall weekend was the quietest since January.[1]

The reviews are close to unanimous: **96 per cent on Rotten Tomatoes from 206 critics**, and 96 from audiences, read on Wednesday morning Singapore time. The score has moved as the count grew — it was reported at 98 at opening — so the number is worth stating with its count and its clock. There is no Singapore release date listed.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT VIEWERS WROTE ABOUT THE HOLMES FILM

Letterboxd's most-liked reviews are the clearest picture of how it is landing, and every surfaced one is four stars or more. **Thomas Flight**, five stars: "*Yes it's about Elizabeth Holmes but really it's a horror film about power, representation in media.*" **theo**, four and a half: "*never has a documentary felt so much like everyone was acting.*" **Joe A**: "*The more you see, the less you know.*" **Kit Lazer**: "*You can roll your eyes if you want to but this is one of the most important works of art of the 21st century.*" The enthusiasm is near-total, which is itself the thing to notice.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · A 96 PER CENT SCORE ON A FILM ABOUT LYING

Across 206 critics, Rotten Tomatoes surfaces no negative excerpt at all, and Letterboxd surfaces nothing below four stars. That is a remarkable consensus on a film whose central question is whether a convicted fraudster should have been handed 174 minutes of sympathetic screen time. The substantive dissent is **National Public Radio's**, which argues the film stacks the deck by setting aside evidence and lets Holmes's claim that she does not lie go largely unchallenged — **but its page returned an error to this desk twice, so the critic is unnamed and nothing is quoted from it.** Worth noting too that the most-liked reviewer above is himself a video essayist with a large audience, not a disinterested viewer. **What would settle it:** a negative notice from a major outlet, which after three weeks has not come.[4]

22

YEARS SINCE A DOCUMENTARY OTHER THAN A CONCERT FILM LAST LED THE AMERICAN BOX OFFICE[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Amy Winehouse's *Back to Black* re-entered the British albums chart at No. 4, up from 112, in its 571st week. It was released in late October 2006; this is a twentieth-anniversary chart. **The chart page publishes no unit figures.**[5]

Manic Street Preachers entered the same chart at No. 10 with *The Holy Bible — Live*, with Tony Iommi new at 11 and Michael Kiwanuka at 13.[5]

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's domestic chart for weekend 44 of 2026, read in the chart body on 3 November; the records and theatre-count context from Rotten Tomatoes' editorial of 1 November. **That piece contradicts its own table on three titles; the chart body is what is printed here.** 2 Rotten Tomatoes' page for the film, read 4 November 2026 at about 04:55 Singapore time, with the critic count as displayed; A24's own synopsis and running time. 3 Letterboxd's popular reviews, read at source 3 November 2026, star ratings as displayed. 4 The aggregate counts as above; **npr.org returned a server error on two attempts, so its review is characterised from a search summary and is neither quoted nor bylined here.** 5 The Official Charts Company's albums chart for 30 October to 5 November 2026, read in the chart body.

THE FAMILY DESK · PUBERTY AND MOOD

A Beijing study ties parents' puberty talk to lower depression in girls

The Beijing Normal University team followed 1,977 seventh-graders for a year, mean age 12.73. Early puberty predicted lower mood only in girls whose parents had not explained it.

Children who reached puberty earlier than their classmates were slightly more likely to be low in mood a year later — but the extra risk showed up only among the girls whose parents had not talked them through the changes. That is the finding of a study of **1,977** Chinese seventh-graders published in the *Journal of Adolescent Health* on **22 October**.[1]

Parents cannot choose when puberty starts. What this work suggests is that the way they handle it is one of the few parts they can choose — and that the choosing matters most for the children it is hardest for, the girls who get there first and alone. It is also, unusually, a study pitched at exactly the right age: the average child in it was **12.73** years old and in their first year of secondary school.[1]

Separately, the Endocrine Society issued a new guideline on genuinely early puberty — a clinical diagnosis, not the ordinary early-ish variety — in June. Its direction is toward less: watch before testing, basal hormone measurement first, **no routine brain scan** in older children without neurological signs. **Stephanie Roberts** of Boston Children's Hospital, who co-chaired it, notes that "*older girls with slowly progressing precocious puberty often have normal adult height without intervention*".[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT CLINICIANS SAY ABOUT EARLY PUBERTY

Beyond the Beijing study, clinicians are unusually explicit that the default for early puberty should be observation. **Ana Claudia Latronico** of the University of São Paulo, who chaired it: "*Children who start puberty earlier than usual should be carefully evaluated.*" Evaluated, not treated — the document offers clinicians "*suggestions that avoid unnecessary or invasive testing and treatment*", recommends four to six months of watching for girls under seven, and says to stop therapy by early adolescence. The practical reading for a parent of a twelve-year-old is that the medical system has moved toward doing less, and that the part left to the household is conversation.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHETHER EARLY PUBERTY'S EFFECT ON MOOD LASTS

The best long-run cohort says it does not. Tarif, Heron, Fraser, Elhakeem and Joinson of Bristol followed **4,607 girls** through the ALSPAC study on seven separate measures of pubertal timing. Later timing was linked to lower odds of depressive symptoms at **14** on six of the seven — and the associations "*attenuated by age 24*", where there was **no evidence** of any link at all. They also warn about the measures themselves: their findings "*advise against using Tanner pubic hair stage 3 and age at axillary hair*", and inconsistency across self-reports "*suggests a need for caution*". The Beijing study used self-reported timing over a single year. **What would settle it:** the same interaction tested in a cohort followed into adulthood. **And the paywall note: this desk could not read the Beijing authors' own limitations section, so none is attributed to them.**[3]

12.73

MEAN AGE OF THE 1,977 CHILDREN IN THE STUDY — THE BAND THAT ACTUALLY CONTAINS A FIRST-YEAR SECONDARY PUPIL[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

An eighty-minute digital lesson in mental-health literacy cut depression and anxiety scores across all 1,080 ninth-graders in one American district, in a preregistered cluster-randomised trial published 27 October. **The abstract reports no effect sizes.**[4]

SOURCES 1 Ren, Zhang, Chaku, Zhao, Li, Qu and Niu, "Early Pubertal Timing and Depressive Symptoms in Boys and Girls", *Journal of Adolescent Health*, online 22 October 2026. **The publisher refused this desk, so the record was read on the European bibliographic service, which returns the publisher's own abstract verbatim; the authors' limitations section was not read and nothing is attributed to it.** 2 The Endocrine Society's clinical practice guideline on central precocious puberty, announced 13 June 2026, read on the society's own newsroom page. 3 Tarif, Heron, Fraser, Elhakeem and Joinson, *British Journal of Psychiatry* 2025;229(3):271–277, read in full. 4 Mrazek and colleagues, *Journal of Adolescent Health*, 27 October 2026. 5 *Scandinavian Journal of Medicine & Science in Sports*, 1 November 2026.

THE TWEEN YEARS · THE SCHOOL TRANSITION

A University of Ottawa team followed 701 teenagers across the move to secondary school

For 10.56 per cent of the Ontario cohort, low mood jumped at the changeover and kept climbing — and by their twenties they were worse off than classmates who started level.

Heather Brittain and Tracy Vaillancourt of the University of Ottawa followed 701 young people from the age of eleven to eighteen, and reported on **15 October** that for about one child in ten the move up to secondary school is not a bump but a turn. Their low mood climbs sharply at the changeover and keeps climbing, and by their twenties they are worse off than classmates who began at the same level.[1]

Most children come through it perfectly well — just over half sat in the group whose mood stayed consistently low-symptom throughout. The useful part is what marked out the ones who did not, because it is almost entirely visible from outside: being bullied at the new school, a rough first few weeks, and having nobody to sit with. Those are things a parent or a form teacher can see.[1]

One caution matters here more than anywhere. The turning point was modelled at the Ontario move from Grade 8 to Grade 9 — ages thirteen to fourteen. Singapore's Primary 6 to Secondary 1 happens a year earlier. A twelve-year-old sits inside the cohort, but the discontinuity is measured a year later in age. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[1]

THE CHATTER · HOW SINGAPORE HANDLES THE SECONDARY TRANSITION

Thinly, in public at least. The schools do the work through parent-engagement sessions and downloadable handbooks: one secondary school's Secondary 1 engagement page, last updated **31 October**, publishes a transition pack and a form teachers' resource, with no narrative and no named staff. The ministry's parents' page carries a guide updated **24 July**. **And the paper landed without a ripple — no press release and no coverage anywhere.** The research exists, the school material exists, and nothing connects them.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT THE OTTAWA TRANSITION STUDY DOES NOT REPORT

No confidence intervals and no standardised effect sizes appear anywhere in the paper's visible text — p-values and raw coefficients only. The much-quoted "declining" group's drop is **statistically null**, p = .208, and the Results section describes it as a three-point decrease where the printed estimate is 3.624. Class separation is modest, so the four groups overlap substantially. And the analytic sample is richer, whiter and better-educated than the children originally recruited — all three differences significant at p < .001 — which undercuts the household-income risk marker the paper foregrounds. **The broader warning comes from an umbrella review of school-structure research published 17 October:** all nine reviews of later school start times agreed the effect exists, and all nine still recommended only limited adoption, because the gains were modest and nothing showed they lasted. **What would settle it:** a replication in a cohort that keeps its poorest families.[3]

10.56%

SHARE OF THE COHORT WHOSE SYMPTOMS ROSE AND KEPT RISING — NOT A DIAGNOSIS RATE[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Californian teenagers under the first statewide later-start law woke 40 minutes later and slept 38 minutes more than peers elsewhere — but daytime sleepiness did not differ. **The authors note they have no data from before the mandate.**[4]

SOURCES 1 Brittain and Vaillancourt, "The secondary school transition as a turning point for internalizing symptoms", *Development and Psychopathology*, published online 15 October 2026, open access, read in full to the limit of what rendered. **The early-adulthood outcome table is an image and its figures are not printed here.** 2 A Singapore secondary school's 2026 Secondary 1 parent-engagement page and the Ministry of Education's parents' resources page, both read at source; **no press release or press coverage of the paper could be found, and the corresponding author's university profile refused this desk.** 3 The paper as above; Floyd, Jenuwine and McBurrows, *Sleep Medicine Reviews* 2026;90:102379, online 17 October 2026. 4 Dong and Troxel, *JAMA Network Open* 2026;9(10):e2638588, 12 October 2026, read in full. 5 Bomans and colleagues, *Journal of Sports Sciences*, 29 October 2026.

THE MACRO DESK · THE REAL RATE

Oil nearly doubled in a year and American inflation expectations fell one basis point

The ten-year Treasury yield rose 82 basis points over twelve months. The real yield rose 83. Every bit of the move was the real rate; none of it was inflation.

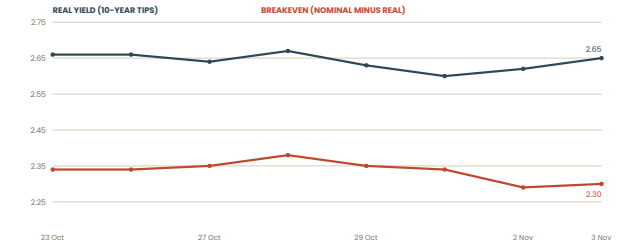
A government bond's yield is really two numbers added together: what lenders demand for parting with the money, and what they expect inflation to take. The American Treasury publishes both — an ordinary ten-year yield and an inflation-protected one — and the difference is the market's own ten-year inflation forecast. On Tuesday 3 November the ordinary yield closed at **4.95 per cent** and the protected one at **2.65**, putting the forecast at **2.30**.[1]

Take the same three numbers twelve months ago. On 3 November 2025 the ordinary yield was **4.13 per cent**, the protected one **1.82**, the forecast **2.31**. So over a year in which crude rose by more than half, American petrol **34.2 per cent** and headline inflation reached **3.7**, the bond market's ten-year inflation forecast went **down one basis point**. The whole of the **82-point** rise in borrowing costs — 83 points of it, in fact — was the real rate.[2]

Read plainly: the market has priced the Gulf war as a tax on growth and a reason for tighter money, not as inflation. That is also what the Federal Reserve did on **28 October**, holding at **3.75 to 4.00 per cent** on a ten-to-two vote in which **both dissenters wanted a rise** — Governor Lisa Cook's first dissent since 2022, alongside Beth Hammack. The Bank of Japan held at **1.25 per cent** two days later with one member pressing for 1.50.[3]

For a global portfolio nothing is working at once: world equities sit **7.0 per cent** below their 52-week high, global bonds **5.5** below theirs, gold **30.1** under a January peak, bitcoin **38.3** under its own. On Tuesday equities and bonds fell together — a rates move, not a growth scare, and the opposite of the diversification a mixed portfolio is bought for. Call the regime higher-for-longer and liquidity-tight. **Explanation, not advice.**[4]

THE DECOMPOSITION · 23 OCTOBER TO 3 NOVEMBER 2026



The real yield ends where it began, at 2.65 per cent; the breakeven falls from 2.34 to 2.30. *Meridian* original, from the Treasury's own daily curves.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT STRATEGISTS SAID ABOUT THE FED'S HOLD

Jeffrey Gundlach of DoubleLine, on the afternoon of the decision: "*I think the Fed should be raising interest rates… What are you waiting for?*" The two-year was **4.714 per cent** as he said it; by Tuesday's close **4.61** — the market moved away from his premise while moving toward his conclusion.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · AGAINST HIGHER-FOR-LONGER AND THE REAL RATE

J.P. Morgan Asset Management's fixed-income group has just raised its fair-value range for the ten-year to **4.50–5.25 per cent**, citing "*long-dated real yields already near cycle highs*". At 4.95 that leaves **30 basis points** of room, by the reckoning of the people who just raised it. **Core inflation is 2.6 per cent**; the 3.7 headline is energy, which policy cannot fix. Employment costs rose **3.4 per cent** against that 3.7, so **real wages fell 0.6 per cent**. **What would settle it:** Friday's payrolls.[6]

SOURCES 1 United States Treasury daily par yield and real yield curves for November 2026, downloaded in full; the breakeven is the subtraction, and the method reproduces the published series exactly on both overlapping days. Market levels read instrument by instrument on 3 November 2026; **the London bullion benchmark and the exchange's own settlements are licence-gated and refused this desk.** 2 The same Treasury series for 3 November 2025; inflation and petrol from the Bureau of Labor Statistics release of 14 October 2026; **oil's twelve-month move is given on the futures basis because the official spot series has not printed since 27 October.** 3 Federal Open Market Committee statement of 28 October 2026 and the Bank of Japan's decision of 30 October, both read at source. 4 Fund levels and 52-week ranges read at source, 3 November 2026. 5 CNBC's live file of the 28 October meeting, each remark individually timestamped. 6 J.P. Morgan Asset Management's fixed-income commentary of 28 October 2026; employment-cost and job-opening data from the Bureau of Labor Statistics, 30 October and 3 November.

THE INVITATION · PINBALL RESTORATION

A Bally of 1969 is easier to repair than a Stern of 2026

Stern sells thirty-four titles from Elk Grove Village, Illinois, at $6,999 to $12,999. A Bally from 1969 has no computer in it at all, which is why people keep them.

Pinball collecting means owning a three-hundred-pound machine in your house, and this page is about why so many collectors choose an old one. The dividing line is 1977. Before it, a pinball machine is electromechanical: the scoring is done by motors, relays and stepper units, the sound by physical bells and chimes, and there is no computer anywhere in the cabinet. After it, there is a circuit board. Everything that follows in this hobby — what people buy, what they pay, what they argue about — comes off that line.[1]

It matters because of what it does to repair. An electromechanical machine can be understood by a patient adult with a multimeter: every function is a wire going somewhere visible, and the parts that wear are springs, contacts and coils that are still made. A solid-state machine from the 1980s or 1990s depends on boards whose chips are out of production, and a machine built this year depends on boards nobody outside the factory can source. The oldest machines in this hobby are the most repairable ones, and that inversion is the whole culture.[1]

The modern end of the market is small, concentrated and surprisingly expensive. **Stern Pinball**, of 1001 Busse Road, Elk Grove Village, Illinois, lists **thirty-four titles** on its own games page, and sells most of them in three tiers — Pro, Premium and Limited Edition. Its Pokémon machine, announced on **14 February 2026** for the franchise's thirtieth anniversary, prices at **$6,999 for the Pro, $9,699 for the Premium and $12,999 for the Limited Edition**, the last of these in a run of **750 worldwide**. The licences tell you who the buyer is: Metallica, Led Zeppelin, Iron Maiden, Rush, The Beatles, Foo Fighters, Jaws, Godzilla, John Wick, James Bond.[2]

The other end is a museum in Alameda, California, that is really an argument. The **Pacific Pinball Museum** keeps **more than a hundred** machines across five rooms, arranged chronologically from the eighteen-hundreds to the 1970s, and sets every one of them to free play — **$22** for an adult, **$12** for a child of five to twelve, **$55** for a family of four. A pinball machine that is not played is furniture; a pinball museum that does not let you play is a warehouse. It also runs a photographic archive of its own collection, machine by machine, and asks the public to help it shoot more.[3]

What the next two pages descend into: what a modern machine actually costs once it is in the room, what a restoration consumes, where the parts come from, and why the people who have done it twice tell you to buy the finished one.

THE CHATTER · WHERE BALLY AND STERN COLLECTORS GATHER

The pinball community is unusually concentrated: one large forum with an attached marketplace, one subreddit, a dense layer of restoration channels on video, and a show calendar that functions as the trading floor. **This desk has to report a failure here, and would rather say so than invent a consensus.** The forum, the subreddit and the hobby's own machine database all refused our requests outright — three separate blocks in one morning — so nothing in these three pages is attributed to a named collector, and no community sentiment is characterised. Everything printed is read on a maker's, dealer's or museum's own page. **That is a thinner desk than the Rabbit Hole should be, and the gap is the editor's to close, not the reader's to guess at.**[4]

750

LIMITED EDITIONS OF STERN'S POKÉMON MACHINE WORLDWIDE, AT $12,999 EACH[2]

SOURCES 1 The electromechanical and solid-state division is the standard period classification used by the hobby's museums and collections, and is reflected in the Pacific Pinball Museum's own chronological room layout; **this desk sets it out from that arrangement and from the machines themselves, not from a hobby database, which refused us.** 2 Stern Pinball's own games page, read 4 November 2026, for the title count, the tier structure and the company's address; the Pokémon prices, the edition size and the 14 February 2026 announcement as reported by Nintendo Life from Stern's promotional material. **Stern publishes no prices on its own site.** 3 The Pacific Pinball Museum's own pages, read 4 November 2026, for the collection size, the room layout and the admission prices. 4 The attempts are the finding: the hobby's main forum, its main subreddit and its machine database each returned a refusal to this desk on 4 November 2026.

THE DEEP END · PINBALL'S THREE TIERS

Jersey Jack and Stern both sell the same machine three times, at three prices

Stern's Pokémon runs $6,999 to $12,999; Jersey Jack's Sonic and Harry Potter run $9,999 to $15,000. The rules code is identical in every tier.

A new pinball machine is sold three times over, and understanding pinball's tier system is the first thing a buyer has to do. Both American manufacturers do it the same way. **Stern** sells Pro, Premium and Limited Edition; **Jersey Jack Pinball** sells Arcade, a middle tier it names for the licence — Wizard for Harry Potter, Special for Sonic — and Collector's. The game you play is the same game. What changes is the hardware under the glass.[1]

What that costs, read off the makers' own pages this week. Stern's Pokémon: **$6,999, $9,699, $12,999**. Jersey Jack's two current titles, Sonic and Harry Potter, are listed at **$9,999 for the Arcade Edition**, **$12,000** for the middle tier and **$15,000** for the Collector's, each shown with a deposit figure beside it. So the cheapest new machine from either maker is about ten thousand American dollars, and the gap between the bottom and the top of one title is a little over five.[2]

What the extra buys, in descending order of honesty: more mechanisms on the playfield that physically move, more of the cabinet art done as decals rather than printed, a different finish, and — at the top tier — a number on a plaque. What it does not buy is more game. The code is the same.[1]

Jersey Jack publishes the figures that describe the size of this business: **over fifteen years** in business, **more than twenty thousand games sold**, in **more than twenty countries**, "designed and manufactured in the USA". Twenty thousand machines in fifteen years is about fourteen hundred a year from one of the two serious makers. This is a hobby whose entire new-machine supply, worldwide, would fit in a warehouse.[2]

Set that against what an electromechanical machine needs: relays cleaned, coils replaced, rubber renewed, a stepper unit adjusted. Every one of those is a mechanical part with a current equivalent, and none of them is a licence.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE PINBALL MAKERS CLAIM FOR THEMSELVES

With the forums closed to this desk, the only voices available are the manufacturers' own, and they are worth reading as marketing rather than as fact. Jersey Jack calls its machines "*playable works of art*" and says they are "*made for players, collectors and newcomers alike*" and "*built to last*", providing owners "*great fun and value for years to come*". It credits itself with "*several industry innovations, including LCD screens, LED lighting, rich audio*" and describes its lighting as "*award-winning*" — **without naming the award.** Stern's own site, by contrast, publishes no prices at all; the figures on this page had to be read off its promotional material as reported elsewhere. **Two makers, one of whom will not print what its product costs.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · WHAT PINBALL'S TOP TIER IS ACTUALLY SELLING

The premium tiers charge for scarcity and trim, not for play. Five thousand dollars separates Stern's Pro from its Limited Edition, and seven hundred and fifty people worldwide may buy the latter; the rules, the shots and the scoring are identical. The out-of-production list on Jersey Jack's own page is the tell — a Toy Story 4 Limited Edition marked down from $12,000 to **$9,999**, and a Guns N' Roses Limited Edition from $11,000 to **$9,000**. A limited edition that goes on sale is a limited edition that did not sell out, which is the honest counterweight to every plaque in this market. **What would settle it:** a maker publishing how many of each tier it actually built. **None of them does.**[2]

~1,400

MACHINES A YEAR, IF JERSEY JACK'S OWN "20,000+ GAMES SOLD" OVER "15+ YEARS" IS READ AS AN AVERAGE[2]

SOURCES 1 Stern Pinball's own games page, read 4 November 2026, which lists Pro, Premium and Limited Edition as its model filters; Jersey Jack Pinball's own site for its three-tier structure. **The statement that the rules code is identical across tiers is the standard structure of this market and is not contradicted on either maker's page; neither maker states it explicitly.** 2 Jersey Jack Pinball's own site, read 4 November 2026, for the tier prices, the discounted out-of-production listings and the company's own figures; the Stern prices as at the previous page. **Both prices are American list prices and exclude delivery, which on a three-hundred-pound cabinet is not trivial.** 3 The maintenance list is the standard service set for electromechanical machines and reflects the Pacific Pinball Museum's own practice of keeping its pre-1970s collection on free play. 4 Jersey Jack Pinball's own marketing copy and help pages, quoted verbatim, read 4 November 2026.

THE DEEP END · PINBALL'S VOCABULARY

Collectors price a Gottlieb by vocabulary alone: woodrail, wedgehead, NIB, HUO

A woodrail is pre-1960; HUO means home use only; NIB means new in box. Each is worth money, and two of the three are unverifiable claims.

Pinball's vocabulary is a price list, and learning it is the cheapest thing a newcomer can do before spending. A **woodrail** is a machine old enough to have wooden side rails rather than metal, which puts it before about 1960. A **wedgehead** is a Gottlieb of the 1960s with a distinctively tapered backbox. **EM** is electromechanical, pre-1977. **NIB** is new in box. **HUO** is home use only — a machine that never stood on a commercial route taking coins from strangers.[1]

Two of those last three are claims rather than facts. A machine in its box can be verified; a machine said to have lived in a living room cannot. The difference between a route machine and a home machine is tens of thousands of plays and therefore the condition of the one part that cannot be replaced cheaply — the playfield itself, which wears where the ball lands.[1]

Which is why the restoration argument divides the hobby into two schools, and both are coherent. The first restores to original: correct parts, original artwork, wear accepted as history, value preserved for a future buyer. The second plays it hard: modern lighting, a replacement playfield where the original is gone, protective overlays, modifications. Each regards the other as missing the point, and the first is usually quieter about the fact that a fully original machine is also an asset.[1]

The honest economics, from the figures this desk could verify. A new machine from either serious maker starts near **$10,000** and runs to **$15,000**. A museum lets you play more than a hundred of them for **$22**. Those two numbers, set beside each other, are the whole argument for lurking before buying: at Alameda's prices a collector could visit four hundred and fifty times for the cost of one Collector's Edition, and would learn, somewhere in the first dozen visits, which three machines they actually want.[2]

And then there is Singapore, where the honest answer is a short one. This desk found no pinball museum, no collectors' club and no dealer here, and importing a three-hundred-pound cabinet is the obvious obstacle. **That absence is the printable fact, and it is why this is a hobby a Singapore reader is likeliest to meet on holiday.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY A WOODRAIL EATS MORE THAN IT RETURNS

The Gottlieb or the woodrail is the cheap part. A project table bought at the bottom of the market arrives needing rubber, lamps, coils, a cleaned playfield and a board nobody makes, and each is an order, a wait and a skill. The upgrade path has no end. The restorer's standard warning is that a finished machine bought from somebody else is almost always cheaper than the same machine restored yourself, because the labour is valued at nothing and the parts at retail. **And one structural risk this desk can verify from the makers themselves:** a modern table that takes its rules over a network depends on that network continuing to exist, which the 1969 machine never did. **What would settle it:** a maker committing in writing to publish final code if it ever stops supporting a title. **None has.**[4]

450

MUSEUM VISITS AT $22 FOR ONE $9,999 MACHINE — THE CASE FOR PLAYING FIRST[2]

NEXT DESCENTS · VOTE FOR TOMORROW'S RABBIT HOLE

Foraging & wild food — identification as a discipline, the legal grey zones, and a near-free hobby with a hard failure mode.

Competitive dog agility — the course, the clock and the clubs; a sport where the equipment is a dog.

Origami & paper craft — the mathematics underneath it, the paper people import, and the folders who publish proofs.

SOURCES 1 The vocabulary and the two restoration schools are the standard terms and the standard argument of this hobby. **This desk sets them out without attribution because the forums, the subreddit and the machine database all refused it on 4 November 2026; no collector is quoted anywhere in these three pages and none should be read as having been.** 2 Prices as on the preceding pages: Jersey Jack Pinball's own listings and the Pacific Pinball Museum's own admission page, both read 4 November 2026; the four-hundred-and-fifty figure is this desk's arithmetic. 3 Searches for a Singapore pinball museum, club, dealer or importer returned nothing this desk could verify. **An absence found by searching is weaker than a presence read at source, and is printed as such.** 4 The network-dependency point is from Jersey Jack Pinball's own help pages, quoted on the previous page. **The restorer's warning is the hobby's standard counsel and is given here without a named source for the reason at note 1.**

FITNESS · PLANT PROTEIN

A São Paulo meta-analysis finds soy and pea shakes match whey for muscle

The São Paulo team pooled five trials and 372 untrained adults, all scanned. The difference in lean mass was 0.35kg in plant protein's favour, and statistically nothing.

Pooling every decent trial that measured bodies with a proper scanner, soy and pea protein shakes built just as much muscle and shed just as much fat as whey in people new to lifting. The analysis, from São Paulo State University, was published in the *Journal of the International Society of Sports Nutrition* on **29 October**.[1]

For a reader in his mid-forties who has been paying a premium for one tub over another, the practical reading is that the lifting and the day's total protein are doing the work, not the label. That is a useful thing to know in a category where almost every piece of public advice is written by somebody selling a tub.[1]

The detail: five trials, **372** untrained adults aged 18 to 59, all measured by scanner. Lean mass differed by **−0.35kg**, interval −2.46 to 1.76; fat mass by **−0.21kg**, interval −2.31 to 1.90. Both supplements improved both measures; neither beat the other. The practical anchors are the society's own: **1.4 to 2.0 grams of protein per kilogram a day**, **20 to 40 grams** a serving, and **700 to 3,000 milligrams of leucine** a dose — that last the operative one, because it is what a plant powder must be dosed up to. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[2]

THE CHATTER · WHO IS TALKING ABOUT SOY, PEA AND WHEY

Almost nobody disinterested, and that is the finding of the São Paulo pooling. Searching the question for 2026 returns supplement retailers and affiliate blogs almost exclusively, every one with a commercial interest in the answer. The two usable voices are the sponsoring society's own position stands, twenty years apart. The **2007** stand: "*the superiority of one protein type over another…remains to be convincingly demonstrated*". The **2017** stand moves the emphasis off the source entirely and onto the leucine dose. **Worth stating: this paper appears in that society's own journal, and the society lists about forty corporate sponsors, among them firms selling both whey and plant powders. The authors declare no conflicts and are publicly funded.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · WHY SOY AND PEA MAY STILL LOSE PER GRAM

Measure muscle synthesis directly and the São Paulo finding weakens: soy, pea and whey are not equal per gram. Lim, Janssen, Currier and colleagues in Stuart Phillips's laboratory at McMaster ran a double-blind crossover with isotope infusion and biopsies. All three supplements raised muscle protein synthesis above fasting. But the plain plant blend raised it **less than the leucine-fortified blend** (p = .002) and **less than whey** (p = .046). Only with leucine added to whey-equivalent levels did it draw level — at **p = .052**, a failure to find a difference, not a demonstration of sameness. And one of the five pooled trials used a **leucine-matched** comparator, so part of the null is a null between matched doses. **The caveat on the sceptic: this desk could not read Phillips's own conflict declarations.**[4]

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HETEROGENEITY ACROSS FIVE POOLED TRIALS — TOO FEW TO DETECT ANY, NOT A LITERATURE THAT AGREES[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Four weeks of handgrip squeezing lowered waking blood pressure about 2.4 points systolic and 4.5 diastolic in 67 medicated hypertensive adults aged 40 to 70 — and knee-extension holds did not. **The 24-hour and sleeping readings showed nothing, and no baseline monitoring was done on the final sample.**[5]

SOURCES 1 Callegari, Silva and Oliveira, São Paulo State University, *Journal of the International Society of Sports Nutrition* 2026;23(1):2752317, online 29 October 2026, open access, read in full; the quoted limitations are the authors' own words. 2 The society's 2017 position stand on protein and exercise, read at source. 3 The society's 2007 and 2017 position stands; its sponsors page, read 3 November 2026. 4 Lim, Janssen, Currier, Paramanantharajah, McKendry, Abou Sawan and Phillips, *Current Developments in Nutrition* 2024;8(6):103769. **The publisher refused this desk; design, results and conclusion were read in the European bibliographic record, and the funding and conflict statements were not.** 5 Oliveira, Waclawovsky and Lehnen, *Clinical Physiology and Functional Imaging* 2026;46(6):e70102, 25 October 2026, open access, read in full. 6 Wei and colleagues, *European Heart Journal* 47(39):5768–5783, issue of 14 October 2026, **published online 29 March 2026**; mean age 61.9.

THE DIARY · TWO BALLOTS THIS FORTNIGHT

KATSEYE opens its Singapore presale on 10 November without publishing a price

Japan's Jump Festa ballot closes at 17:59 on 16 November, and it is free. Sumo's January advance sale opens 5 December, with the price table still empty.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

12 Nov–27 Dec ★ **Monkey Goes West · Wild Rice**
NGEE ANN KONGSI THEATRE, FUNAN · **$50–$120** · RECOMMENDED AGE 5 AND UP — **THE FAMILY PICK, AND SIX WEEKS OF DATES**

13–22 Nov ★ **Singapore Writers Festival · Hidden in Plain Sight**
VICTORIA THEATRE, THE ARTS HOUSE, NATIONAL GALLERY · **FESTIVAL PASS $30, YOUTH PASS $15** COVERING 100-PLUS PROGRAMMES · AMITAV GHOSH ON 14 NOV

20–29 Nov **Kalaa Utsavam · 25th Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · FROM **$29**; **SIX PROGRAMMES FREE** · SACHIN–JIGAR DEBUT, **NO PRICE PUBLISHED**

27 Nov–3 Jan ★ **Christmas Wonderland · 13th edition**
SUPERTREE GROVE & MEADOW · **6.30–11PM DAILY**, LAST ENTRY 10.15 · **THE DATES ARE FINALLY PUBLISHED; THE PRICE IS NOT — "TICKET PRICES WILL BE RELEASED SOON"**

21–24 Jan ★ **ART SG 2027**
MARINA BAY SANDS EXPO · **TWO-FOR-ONE EARLY BIRD ENDS 11.59PM, 24 NOVEMBER** — TWO WEEKEND ADULT TICKETS **$44** INSTEAD OF $88 · **UNDER-16S FREE WITH AN ADULT**

10 FEB **KATSEYE · The Wildworld Tour**
INDOOR STADIUM · **NO PRICE PUBLISHED** · PRESALES FROM **10 NOV NOON**, GENERAL SALE **13 NOV**

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

11–13 Dec **Tokyo Comic Con · tenth anniversary**
MAKUHARI MESSE · THREE-DAY PASS **¥9,900**, **PRIMARY AND UNDER FREE** WITH A GUARDIAN · A NICOLAS CAGE PHOTO IS **¥34,000**

19–20 Dec ★ **Jump Festa 2027**
MAKUHARI MESSE, 9AM–5PM · **FREE, BUT INVITATION ONLY** — EVERYONE OF PRIMARY AGE UP NEEDS A TICKET IN THE JUMP NAVI APP · **THE BALLOT CLOSES 17:59 ON 16 NOVEMBER**

10–24 Jan ★ **Hatsu Basho · January Grand Sumo**
RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ADVANCE SALE OPENS 5 DECEMBER**; **THE ASSOCIATION SAYS PRICES ARE BEING REVISED AND ITS TABLE IS EMPTY** · NOVEMBER'S KYUSHU TOURNAMENT IS SOLD OUT ON ALL FIFTEEN DAYS

4–11 Feb **Sapporo Snow Festival 2027**
ODORI, SUSUKINO AND TSUDOME · **DATES NOW PUBLISHED, ADMISSION NOT** — AND THE ENGLISH PAGE STILL SHOWS 2025

PLANNING NOTES

Two ballots, both closing before this month is out. Jump Festa's application window runs to **17:59 Japan time on 16 November** and the event is free; apply before you book flights. KATSEYE's ladder starts **10 November at noon** with the membership presale, runs through two bank windows on the 11th and the artist presale on the 12th, and opens generally at **10am on 13 November** — with no price band published anywhere, so set the alarm and budget blind.

Sumo teaches the lesson: buy on day one. The association's English page marks this month's Kyushu tournament sold out on all fifteen days. Tokyo's January advance sale opens **Saturday 5 December** with its price table still empty, because prices are being revised.

For a twelve-year-old: *Monkey Goes West* is the straightforward yes — age 5 and up, from $50. ART SG admits under-16s free with a ticketed adult, and that early-bird dies at **11.59pm on 24 November**.

Three items this desk withholds. A price for Christmas Wonderland, because Gardens by the Bay says only that prices "will be released soon". A Singapore run of *Moulin Rouge!*, for the third issue running. And this December's Singapore marathon as bookable — **entries closed at 23:59 on 31 October. Marina Bay Sands and both big ticketing sites refused this desk again.**

SOURCES 1 Every Singapore entry read on the promoter's or venue's own page, 3–4 November 2026: Live Nation Singapore's event pages, singaporeballet.org, wildrice.com.sg, srt.com.sg, esplanade.com, singaporewritersfestival.com, artsg.com and the Gardens by the Bay calendar. 2 Every Japan and region entry read at its official site: tokyocomiccon.jp, jumpfesta.com, sumo.or.jp, snowfes.com, ausopen.com and artbasel.com. **The Sapporo dates were read on the organiser's Japanese page; its English page still displays 2025.** 3 **Events this desk could not confirm from a primary source are not listed** — a dozen widely advertised concerts appear only on aggregators, and both major Singapore ticketing sites and the integrated resort's own pages refused or returned errors.

THE TABLE · FOUR NEW OPENINGS

Orchard Road's Nekobushi sells a hundred udon bowls a day, by reservation only

Two bowls, one dashi, fourteen seats and no walk-ins. A new week of slots opens on Saturdays at noon, announced by a Telegram bot named after a cat.

Nekobushi is the hardest table in Orchard Road at the moment, and it serves exactly two dishes. Fourteen seats in the Orchard Plaza unit that held a viral ramen pop-up until July, it pairs that team with chef Koki Miyoshi of the izakaya Hearth. Both bowls share one dashi of bonito, mackerel, sardine, flying fish and kombu, no monosodium glutamate: **kitsune at $14.80**, with two kinds of fried tofu, one simmered from Niigata and one crisp from Ehime; **gyu at $18.80**, from Osaka kasu udon, with beef short rib and crisp wagyu intestine. It opened **7 October**.[1]

The reception is consistent and the advice is the same from both outlets that have been: order both. HungryGoWhere prefers the kitsune for a layered broth; The Ranting Panda singles out the simmered tofu, and finds the gyu oilier. Both flag the same risk — that a diner reads the kitsune as bland before using the condiment bar. **No critic has reviewed it.** Booking is by Telegram bot, a new week opening Saturdays at noon; three people per booking; PayNow only.[1]

Woodsmen by Cut Butchery is the opposite proposition: no booking at all unless you are eight or more. A butchery at the front of a Thomson Plaza unit, a hundred-odd seats behind, Australian ironbark in the grill — you buy the meat at retail and the kitchen cooks it. **MB4-plus ribeye $13 per 100g**, **A5 wagyu $38**, spit-roast chicken **$18.80 the half**, **no service charge**. The Ranting Panda scores it four out of five and counted thirty people queueing on a Friday. The Ordinary Patrons is warmer on the room than the food, and adds the correction everyone else missed: **some cooking methods do carry a charge**.[2]

Nomad Kitchen is thirty years of hotel kitchens reduced to a Taman Jurong stall. Fuad Salim cooks from seven countries — Iran, Turkey, Italy, Greece, Morocco, Saudi Arabia, Afghanistan — from scratch daily: **saffron jujeh $8**, Afghan chicken from **$6**, iskender **$12**, lasagna **$8.50**. Eatbook scores it **8.5 out of 10** and makes the jujeh its favourite, with the criticism that the chicken is slightly bland because the seasoning sits on the skin. **Beyond that one review there is almost nothing, no opening date is published, and while the stall is Muslim-owned no source states it is halal-certified.**[3]

THE VERDICT · WHERE TO GO THIS MONTH

Nekobushi if you will set a Saturday alarm — it is the only one of the four with a real consensus behind it, and the only one where the obstacle is access rather than doubt. **Woksta** for ten dollars and a genuinely new idea, accepting the chef says he is still tuning it. **Woodsmen** for a group of eight. **Nomad Kitchen** on one strong review. **A caution for the round-up season:** two venues doing the rounds of local "new openings" lists this month opened in **May and August 2025**. They are not new.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · HOW NEW THESE FOUR OPENINGS REALLY ARE

Three of the four have never been reviewed by a critic, and the fourth has been reviewed once. Every verdict on this page comes from food blogs and local food media, one of which discloses a hosted visit; there is no Michelin entry and no newspaper critic among them. **Woodsmen opened in August and still has exactly one full tasting on record.** That is not a complaint about the places — it is the state of Singapore restaurant criticism this month, and it is why this page prints the queue length, the sell-out time and the booking mechanics, which are facts, alongside opinions that are mostly one person's. **What would settle it:** a published review of any of the four.[4]

RESERVATION ONLY · WALK-IN ONLY · HAWKER · NO SERVICE CHARGE · TOO NEW TO CALL

SOURCES 1 The restaurant's own site for the menu, prices, hours, booking rules and allergens, read 3 November 2026; HungryGoWhere, 9 October 2026, and The Ranting Panda, 16 October 2026. **The venue's own release schedule and HungryGoWhere's account of it disagree; the venue's is printed.** 2 The venue's own site; The Ranting Panda, 11 October 2026, with its scores; The Ordinary Patrons, 31 August 2026. 3 HungryGoWhere, 23 October 2026, which interviewed the chef and supplies the opening date; Eatbook, 2 November 2026. **A third outlet's review refused this desk and is not quoted.** 4 The reviews above; opening dates for the two recycled venues from their own 2025 coverage.

THE UNDERCURRENT · THAILAND'S HORSE ACCOUNTS

The Bank of Thailand's horse list runs to 246,000 names and 3.56 million accounts

A third of them have no complainant. In Thailand a delivery rider has been frozen since April over a transfer of 140 baht, and no court hears an appeal against a listing.

In Thai a money mule is a horse — **บัญชีม้า**, *banchee ma*, the horse account: the animal that carries somebody else's load. The word has been in the newspapers since the scam compounds went industrial. What is new, and what nobody outside Thailand has written up, is that Thais have started using it about themselves. On Pantip, the country's main public forum, people post sentences like "*the bank told me I'm a light-brown horse account*". A risk code has become an identity.[1]

There are five colours, and since **23 December 2025** they have been black-letter law. A Bank of Thailand notification published in the Royal Gazette defines the black horse (on the anti-money-laundering list), the dark-grey (a victim has filed a report) and the light-grey (in the money trail, **no complaint filed**), and requires every payment provider to treat all three as high risk: money in and out suspended, every card stopped, nothing new opened. Beneath them sit two brown tiers, where the *bank* merely found your behaviour odd. The central bank's own public answers concede that the light-grey and brown tiers — the ones with no victim and no report — are **about a third of all horse accounts**.[2]

The scale is genuinely enormous. By July 2025 the central bank counted **2.8 million accounts suspended** against **197,000 names** — about ten accounts a person. By May 2026 the digital ministry's own committee put it at **3.56 million accounts** and more than **246,000 names**, with about **8,000 million baht** frozen.[3]

And the policy works, on the measure it chose. Victim losses peaked at **8,590 million baht** in the second quarter of 2024, fell to **5,651 million** a year later and to about **1,810 million** in the second quarter of 2026 — a fall of about **79 per cent** on the regulator's own series. No country in the region has a better number to show.[4]

That is the sentence the wire stories end on. The rest of this essay is about what the number is measured against.

> ***"It isn't enough that earning the money exhausts you — now you have to be exhausted over the money you already earned."***

Thailand did not criminalise fraud. It criminalised the account, and then stopped policing accounts and started policing persons. In June 2024 the central bank moved to person-level management: one flagged transfer contaminates everything you hold, at every institution in the country. **Wiparat Khunart**, who runs a durian stall in Khon Kaen, had about **169,000 baht** in her account when **16,000** arrived from a suspected horse account. The bank froze **160,000** of it, told her the police had ordered it, and sent her to a cyber unit she could not reach. She got her money back about **eighteen hours** after her Facebook post had been shared nearly twenty thousand times. In Thailand today, redress for a financial blacklisting is a function of virality.[5]

The lawyers have noticed. **Decha Kittiwittayanan**, quoted in *Daily News* in September 2025: freezing innocent people's deposits "*in a cast-the-net-wide fashion…is unjust enforcement of the law*". The same report carries a market vendor frozen for nearly two months who assembled, by her own account, about **twenty kilogrammes** of documents; and a delivery rider frozen since April over an inbound transfer of **140 baht**, still frozen after proving his innocence.[6]

SOURCES 1 Thread titles and opening posts on Pantip, read 3 November 2026; **the comment panes require a login, so only the opening posts were read and no commenter is named here.** 2 Bank of Thailand notification 58/2568 of 11 December 2025, published in the Royal Gazette volume 142, special part 397 ง, 22 December 2025, effective 23 December; the one-third figure from the central bank's own published answers. Both read at source in Thai. 3 The central bank's media briefing deck of 19 August 2025, text extracted from its own portable document; the 2026 figures from the digital ministry's technology-crime committee of 7 May 2026 as reported by Thai PBS Verify, 15 May 2026. **That report contradicts itself between its standfirst and its body; the body figures are used.** 4 The central bank's quarterly series, the first two readings from the August 2025 deck and the 2026 reading as reported by *Thansettakij*, 26 August 2026. 5 The Thaiger's Thai edition, 15 September 2025. 6 *Daily News*, 14 September 2025.

The design explains the result. An emergency decree of March 2023 made it a crime, punishable by up to three years, to lend your account to another knowing it would be used in crime, and capped a provider's own suspension at **seven days**. An amendment in April 2025 removed the ceiling in practice: it created a technology-crime operations centre inside the digital ministry with power to suspend accounts immediately and to publish name lists, and obliged institutions to refuse, suspend or close accounts **until delisting**.[1]

Then it did the thing that makes the rest inevitable. Section 8/10 makes a bank, a digital-asset firm, a mobile operator or a social platform **co-liable for a victim's loss unless it can prove** it met the regulators' standards. A bank that under-freezes pays damages. A bank that over-freezes pays nothing, and there is no court to which the freeze itself can be taken — the only judicial route in the statute is a thirty-day civil petition against a decision about a refund. Mass over-freezing is not a failure of this design. It is the equilibrium it was built to produce.[1]

And the burden of proof is inverted. To clear the lightest listing — the one that requires no victim and no complaint — you must appear **in person at a branch**, submit to enhanced due diligence, and prove a negative. If you succeed, the provider may reopen **that one account**.[2]

A bank that under-freezes pays damages. A bank that over-freezes pays nothing.

It falls hardest on exactly the people whose living is high-churn, low-value, stranger-to-stranger money: market traders, riders, resellers, the recently banked. Which is to say, on the population that Thailand's cashless build-out was celebrated for bringing in.[2]

The regulator does not deny the cost. **Ormon Chanthaphan**, who runs payment-systems policy and consumer protection at the central bank, has acknowledged that innocent parties may be widely affected, and that the same strict measures apply to disputes over online purchases worth a few hundred baht. The bank's defence, stated on the record in September 2025, is that only accounts genuinely in the money trail are touched, and, in August 2026, that *"having your account suspended does not mean you did wrong"*. It has built real remedies to match: verified innocent holders unfrozen within **four hours**, three review rounds a day at eleven, three and seven, automatic review of any freeze lasting over seven days, and a hotline. From August 2026 victims can be refunded without waiting for a court order.[3]

A four-hour unfreeze that you must trigger yourself, by telephone, in person, with documents, is a service level. It is not a right.

The scale of the enforcement asymmetry is the number the whole policy turns on. A government spokesperson put the nine months from October 2025 to June 2026 at **more than 351,000 mule accounts closed and more than 29,000 suspects arrested**, with **3.6 billion baht** frozen and warrants out for seventy ringleaders. Set that against **3.56 million accounts suspended** and **246,000 names** listed. An earlier government figure is starker still: **1.66 million accounts suspended to December 2024 against 2,495 account-holders arrested** in twelve months.[5]

Those two columns describe a state that can disable a person's economic life at the rate of a million a year and prosecute at the rate of a few thousand. The listing is not a step toward a charge. For the overwhelming majority of the names on it, the listing *is* the entire legal event — imposed administratively, borne indefinitely, and lifted, if at all, by appearing at a counter with documents.[5]

Meanwhile the market did what markets do. On **26 and 27 October 2026** the police broke a network run through **more than 1,500 shell companies** registered on the commerce department's own online portal, linked to about **1,060 fraud cases** and **379 million baht** of losses across 255 accounts from 189 companies. Eleven arrests; **239 passbooks and 222 company seals** seized, with the machine that made them. The operation had switched from individual to corporate accounts in mid-2024 because corporate accounts carried higher limits and **required no face scan** — and it coached its recruits with artificial intelligence so they could rehearse company details convincingly enough to satisfy a bank clerk.[4]

SOURCES 1 The Emergency Decree on Measures for the Prevention and Suppression of Technology Crimes of 2023, Royal Gazette volume 140 part 18 ก, 16 March 2023, sections 6, 9 and 10; and Amendment No. 2 of 2025, Royal Gazette volume 142 part 27 ก page 5, 12 April 2025, sections 4/2, 8/2, 8/5, 8/10 and 8/11. Both read at source in Thai. **No section of either provides a court route against a suspension.** 2 The December 2025 notification's delisting procedure, read at source. 3 The payment-systems director quoted 16 September 2025; the central bank's own statements of 13 September 2025 and 26 August 2026, with Assistant Governor Daranee Saejoo named; the remedies as published by Thai PBS, 15 September 2025. 4 The Crime Suppression Division's press conference of 27 October 2026, led by Pol. Lt. Gen. Nattasak Chaowanasai, as reported by The Standard and a Bangkok radio newsroom the same day. 5 Figures given by a Thai government spokesperson, reported by Xinhua, 13 July 2026, against the suspension totals on the preceding page. **Single-sourced: this desk could not read the arrest and closure figures on any Thai government site.**

Japan tried this first, and has been at it for eighteen years. It criminalised the sale of bank accounts and passbooks in 2008 and raised the penalty in 2011. The supply did not shrink: by 2024 arrests for account trading were about **three and a half times** the 2011 level, and in 2025 the national police recorded **5,315 cases and 3,657 people** arrested for the trade in accounts and phones.[1]

And the fraud it was meant to stop hit a record. Japan's special-fraud total for 2025: **27,832 recognised cases**, up 32.3 per cent, and **¥142.31 billion** of losses, up **98 per cent** — nearly doubled in a single year, running at about **¥390 million a day**. In January 2026 the police expert panel concluded that deterrence remains **insufficient** and recommended raising the penalties again.[2]

That is the ratchet, and it is what Thailand has bought. Criminalising the supply of identity does not close the market; it raises the price, pushes recruitment down the social scale, and generates a permanent enforcement caseload that governments read as evidence the penalties are too low. Japan's word for the recruitment is *yami baito*, dark side-jobs. Thailand's is a Facebook advertisement and **400 baht** — what one man, arrested on a warrant dated **24 July 2026**, said he was paid for an account that now carries four warrants and nearly a million baht of alleged damage. A 2024 Supreme Court judgment has closed the defence: being hired to open an account is an offence even where the holder says they were deceived.[3]

Eighteen years in, Japan is escalating for the third time while losses double. Thailand is three years in.

The recruiting pool is moving the way the precedent predicts. Youth horse accounts rose from **3,371 in January 2025 to 5,741 in March 2026**, up **70.3 per cent**, with linked losses over **185 million baht**. The response, completed across September and October 2026, was a daily transfer cap by age, from **3,000 baht** at ten to **10,000** at eighteen. The central bank says more than **97 per cent** of customers are unaffected, which is both true and the point.[4]

Follow the money instead and the same displacement shows up. Criminals used to move funds through five or six hops before converting to cryptocurrency; the central bank says they now use **one hop, straight to crypto**, with about **three-quarters** of receiving accounts on Thai-licensed exchanges. A shorter chain is faster and harder to trace, not easier. Corporate horse accounts appeared, the regulator says, *because individual accounts can no longer be opened.*[5]

And cash came back. In September 2025 the central bank had to explain in public that an abnormal surge in withdrawals was fear of its own measures, with shops putting up signs refusing transfers. From **1 April 2026** a withdrawal of five million baht or more requires a declared purpose; from **October 2026** a deposit of that size requires a declared source. Freeze the rails, watch people flee to cash, then require them to account for the cash.[6]

A country has normalised a nationwide, non-judicial financial blacklist, run by a ministry committee and a central-bank notification, with the bank as adjudicator and no appeal to a court against the listing itself. The rails are generic. They work beautifully on scam money. They will work exactly as well on whatever the next list-maker decides to name. **A transfer of 140 baht froze a delivery rider's account for five months, against 246,000 names on a list no judge has ever seen.**

WHAT THIS DESK KILLED, AND WHAT IT COULD NOT READ

Dropped at verification: the widely circulated claim that **140,000 million baht** of old thousand-baht notes have vanished from the banking system because political clans are hoarding them to buy votes. It is attributed to the governor only second-hand, hedged in its own source, and the vote-buying link is the outlet's speculation. **No central-bank release carries it.** Also dropped: the crypto press's framing that Thailand "froze three million accounts" in one sweep — it is a cumulative total since 2023, across three agencies and seventeen institutions. **Could not read:** the central bank's statistics portal, so the cash claim rests on its statements not its series; the Bangkok Post's two best pieces, paywalled; and the five Western outlets this desk checks for prior coverage, all of which block its crawler — **three differently framed searches surfaced none of them and no secondary piece cites any, but the check is indirect and is declared as such.**

SOURCES 1 Japan's National Police Agency expert panel as reported by Jiji Press, 8 January 2026; the 2025 arrest figures from the agency's own release. 2 Japan's National Police Agency special-fraud statistics for 2025, release dated 22 May 2026, text extracted from the agency's own portable document. 3 Amarin TV and TNews case reports of 2026; the Supreme Court judgment as summarised by a Thai legal-education site. 4 Reported from police online data, October 2025 to May 2026, by *Thansettakij*, 2 August 2026, with the central bank's spokesperson Chayawadee Chaiyanan named. 5 The central bank's own briefing, with Deputy Governor Roong Mallikamas and Assistant Governor Daranee Saejoo, as reported by Workpoint Today. 6 The central bank's statements of 13 and 15 September 2025; the declaration rules as reported by Bangkok Biznews and Thai PBS Policy Watch. 7 This desk's own argument from the figures above.

THE LAST WORD

The reference price

A chip company agreed on Sunday to buy a laser company for one hundred and fifteen billion dollars, and by Tuesday the same deal was worth about seventy-nine (p7). Nothing was renegotiated. The buyer is paying in its own shares, and its own shareholders spent three days deciding what those were worth. The premium, meanwhile, is measured against a price from the day before the talks leaked — a Tuesday valuation of a Wednesday company.

The same question runs through the book. A ten-year yield rose eighty-two basis points in a year, and eighty-three of them were the real rate, which means the largest oil shock in a decade put nothing at all into the price of expected inflation (p14). A patch made two machines read a document sixty per cent faster, except on the pair belonging to the man who founded the project, where it did nothing (p8). A tablet has three storage sizes and three different processors, stated once, in a table (p9). A watch is engraved “limited 100 pcs” on a caseback its maker’s own page does not mention (p10).

And a hand saw is sold on hardness, where hardness is the thing that makes it disposable (p6). Read the number against the wrong thing and you buy the wrong saw. Thailand has three and a half million accounts frozen and a seventy-nine per cent fall in reported losses, and nobody can yet say whether that measures crime leaving the country or crime leaving the part of the country that counts (p21).

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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A note on method. This edition’s load-bearing documents were read where they are published. Marvell’s merger agreement and four other filings were read on the Securities and Exchange Commission’s own system; the United States Treasury’s daily par and real yield curves supplied both yield lines on p14, and the breakeven is this desk’s own subtraction, validated against the published series; Singapore’s gazetted holiday list, the Manpower Ministry’s release and the Reserve Bank of Australia’s statement were read at source; two Thai statutes and a central-bank notification were read in Thai, and two Japanese police releases in Japanese. **Where a host refused us we have said so on the page. The Rabbit Hole is thinner than it should be for exactly that reason, and says so on p15.**